

humble boy who stepped in to help his batchmates. "He would calmly reassure us and encourage us to keep going. Those words of encouragement and conversations were pivotal for me, and I pushed myself to work hard and overcome the language barrier. Whatever I am today, I owe to that turning point," Rajat recalls.

Today, Prof. Pawan Kumar is a faculty member in the Department of Mathematics at IIT Kharagpur.

Motivated by his friend, Rajat realised that language was merely a tool for communication. Surrounded by students from across the country, Rajat's harmonious upbringing helped him form close friendships with peers, including some from non-Hindi-speaking states who were proficient in English but struggled with Hindi. Together, they all overcame language barriers and became lifelong friends.

Tryst with destiny

Pursuing higher studies abroad after graduation was never on Rajat's agenda. While his peers took the GRE and TOEFL exams, Rajat felt no desire to leave India. "The education I received here instilled a sense of duty to contribute to my country," Rajat says. In 1983, as a backup, he took the second edition of the GATE exam, in case he didn't secure a job, and was accepted into the MTech programme at IISc in Bengaluru. However, fate steered him towards the industry, and in 1985, he secured a job at Hindustan Computers Limited (HCL).

At the time, HCL was just beginning to manufacture PCs, albeit with limited capacity. Rajat's work primarily involved routine tasks, which did not stimulate his intellectual curiosity. "Despite being in R&D, we were often asked to help on the assembly floor with PC manufacturing. I approached my boss for more challenging work, but even those tasks weren't enough to fully engage me," he recalls.

However, fate had more in store for Rajat. A letter from IISc, addressed to his family home in Bareilly, arrived with an interview call for the MSc Engineering programme. Recognising the significance, Rajat's younger brother immediately left for Delhi to deliver the letter to him. "He even booked a train reservation for me and brought the ticket with the call letter. Since the ticket was already booked, I decided to attend the interview," Rajat shares. His manager at HCL encouraged him to go, reassuring him that he could always return.



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